This ethical relationship with nature was based on the fundamental belief that there was a spiritual dimension to the earth, of which humans too were a part (but only a part), and it was believed that upsetting the balance of nature would not go unpunished by it.

The natives' respect for nature gave rise to their faith, and the symbols or icons used were inspired by animals and landforms, thereby putting nature at the centre of their lives. Connections among members of the community were forged through specific traditions.[9] Even their epistemology revolved around nature and communal harmony. It was this deeply spiritual relationship, embedded in traditional practices and oral knowledge of tribe elders that constituted their 'religion', thus tying together nature, faith and knowledge.[10]

On a related note, perhaps followers of certain Indic schools of philosophy can relate to the beliefs of the Siouan culture as depicted by Brown in his book *The Sacred Pipe*.[11] The Siouan people believed that the whole of creation was essentially one and that all parts within the whole were related. What was particularly interesting was the way the Sioux referred to each other in relational terms. For instance, an old woman would be addressed as 'mother' and a much older woman as 'grandmother'. Such an approach to human relations is a direct corollary of the community's spiritual attitude to nature. All of this changed when Columbus' Christian expeditionary party landed on the shores of America with an intention to colonise it.

When the European coloniser set foot on the American soil, he was staunchly rooted in the Christian belief that humans were above other creatures since humans (read the White Christian) were 'beings' because they possessed souls, and the rest were 'non-beings' because they had no souls. Christianity placed the 'human being', preferably the Christian White European, above the rest of creation, thereby furthering the belief that nature existed solely for the 'pursuit of his happiness' and his 'manifest destiny'. The difference in the attitudes of the Native Americans and the coloniser towards nature could not have been starker. One worshipped nature and saw himself as a part of it, while the other put himself above nature and sought to enjoy its plenty as a matter of divinely ordained right. It is no surprise then that 'humanism' and 'materialism' are the direct consequences of the coloniser's OET, which, among other things, gave birth to a Cartesian dualistic approach, whose distinction between subject/mind